TradeCheck AI: Business Case

For the owner or operations manager of a small freight forwarder | Pratikkumar Hirpara, November 2026

The problem

Before every import is declared, someone has to compare the invoice, packing list and certificate of origin line by line and find the right customs (HS) code for each product. This takes about 22 minutes per shipment, so a forwarder handling 300 shipments a month spends about 110 staff hours, or about **€4,950 a month**, on checking paperwork. Mistakes that slip through cause rework, containers waiting at the port and wrong duty.

The solution

TradeCheck AI reads the three documents, points out anything that does not match, and suggests the customs code for each product with a quote from the official tariff. Your broker gets a short report in about 22 seconds and only has to review and approve it. When anything is unclear, the shipment is sent to a person with the reason; nothing is ever filed automatically. In tests on 29 shipments it caught 23 of 23 planted problems with no false alarms.

Cost

- **To build:** about 100 hours of work, valued at €4,500 (estimate), and €0 external costs, because every tool ran on a free plan.
- **To run:** about €187 a month: €7 for AI usage on the paid tier and 4 hours of upkeep. Hosting is €0 on a local n8n; a cloud server and paid database would add about €33.

Value

Per month, 300 shipments	Today (manual)	With TradeCheck AI
Staff time for checks and classification	€4,950	€2,115
AI usage (paid tier)		€7
Upkeep (4 hours)		€180
Hosting and database (local n8n, free plans)		€0
Total monthly cost	**€4,950**	**€2,302**
Monthly saving		**€2,648**

Payback in 1.7 months; +€27,273 after the first 12 months. It still pays back within 3.1 months if manual work is 20% faster and review 20% slower than assumed. 59 staff hours a month are freed for more shipments. Savings from avoided errors are not counted, because they cannot be estimated reliably yet.

Measured: 22 second run time, 10% of runs falling back to manual checks during testing, €0 build costs. Assumed: volume, 22 minutes manual time (industry benchmark, not yet timed by us), 8 minutes review time, €45 per hour labour cost (German average). Details and sources in the ROI model.

Recommendation

Approve a three month pilot with one freight forwarder handling at least 100 shipments a month, using real documents under a data processing agreement. Extra cost: about 20 hours of setup (login, paid AI tier, full tariff) and under €100 for AI usage. We measure manual time before and review time after. Continue if review takes at most half of the measured manual time and no wrong code passes broker review unflagged; otherwise stop with a clear lesson learned.